

advance, just as they would prepare for important business meetings. They should review the agenda ahead of time and be ready to ask questions and debate the topics.

It is also a good idea to have a family office staff member on hand at Family Council meetings to clarify issue or answer questions that council members might have. Typically, family offices, which manage the details of a family's wealth, have a bookkeeper or trustee who can be very helpful at family meetings. There may be important footnotes and elucidations that the family office person can provide.

Our family held our first official Family Council meeting during Thanksgiving 2010. This is when we “institutionalized” our family office. Our goals for this meeting were to:

- Introduce the family office concept to the family.
- Organize the family budgets.
- Get everyone thinking about how we can work together on family projects.
- Start to get the system of family governance working.

Up to this point, your authors had talked a little about the family office project to other family members. It was nothing more than a peculiar abstraction as far as the rest of the family was concerned.

Our Thanksgiving meeting made the family office more concrete. For the first time, it drew a clear distinction between family office projects and resources and the elder author's personal projects and resources.

This distinction (made official by legal documents) is what brings the family office into being. Certain assets are designated for the family. Others remain in individual hands. Until the wealth creator in your family does this, you don't have family money.

Leading up to our first family meeting, we worked hard on the agenda for the meeting. We tried to make the meeting as interesting and as accessible as possible for the other family members. And we limited the meeting to four hours.

Here's how we structured our first Family Council meeting: